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Al Tinney

Pianist Al Tinney was born in Ansonia, Connecticut on May 28, 1921 and died in Buffalo, New York on December 11, 2002. He appeared in the original production of Porgy & Bess *as a child performer and later led the house band at Monroe's Uptown House in New York City. Al took part in the musical experiments that gave birth to bebop and his playing foreshadowed that of Bud Powell, Al Haig and Duke Jordan. He was a well known musical figure in Buffalo and taught and performed at SUNY Buffalo.*

Al was interviewed in Buffalo, NY on October 14, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Buffalo, New York filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Mr. Al Tinney with me today.

AT: Thank you.

MR: It's a pleasure to meet you after reading about you. I always like to think of a nice way to start and I think I'll use something you said in one of your interviews and that was when you put your foot in something, something usually happens.

AT: Oh yes. After several decades something should happen.

MR: Something should happen.

AT: Like you wait a long time for something to happen and all of a sudden there it is. It's funny. But it's something that you have to wait for. You can't push it. That's the funny thing. It's like phone calls. Sometimes you're waiting for a phone call and if they don't call you when you think they should you have the urge to call them. Like what's up. And if you wait, you say okay, I'll wait a few minutes longer. And then your call comes. You see?

MR: It's all in the timing, isn't it?

AT: Yep. Patience is virtue or something like that.

MR: Yeah. That's right.

AT: I have no idea.

MR: You seem to have stressed in some of the things I've read that you really like to have some organization in your playing. And I think about those jam sessions in Monroe's and all that, and you seem to have a need to put some organization to it?

AT: To the playing or the—

MR: To the whole ensemble I guess.

AT: Oh I guess — you know some things you just can't harness. You have to just let them go on their own. It seems to form its own self. You know what I mean?

MR: Right.

AT: And so this organizational mind of mine, it's sort of methodical. I like, you know like on my job I have a certain system that I use to play, which is — it's not chaos but there's no strictness to it. There's no commitment to it you know. We get on the bandstand and I'll start off an introduction or something — an interesting thing, a young man, his name was Meister — Jeff Meister — drums with Michael Sidisky. And he plays with us sometimes, with Advantage you know. When I need a substitute he comes in. And the funny thing he said is who counts off? Because there was never anybody — I never count off. I set a tempo by the piano and then I'll hit [scats] and —

MR: And you're in.

AT: Yeah.

MR: Well Count Basie used to do that, didn't he?

AT: Yeah, that's right. Well maybe I'm using the tricks of the old trade or the old tricks of the trade.

MR: Maybe he stole it from you, what do you think?

AT: I'm not that old I don't think. I'm not that old. But like I say we didn't have this format when we came to Fanny's. It just developed as the time went by. It didn't take us long to do this because I have two exceptionally fine musicians, you know, the drummer is Louie Marino, and the bass player Sabu Adeola, who, he's wanted all over town by the right people.

MR: Right. He's not on a wanted poster in the post office.

AT: He has — we all have our faults — his is being late. Like on jobs he comes in after you expect him.

MR: I see. Kind of like the phone call you were talking about.

AT: Yes. So that's the thing with organizing something or trying to put something in a trap. Sometimes it'll evade the trap, it'll avoid the trap and try to do something else. So like I say the system that we had developed. It wasn't meant to be, it was just you know the same tunes I know, and you give the drummer the right key—

MR: That's important.

AT: I always say to the drummer "E flat." And so and the bass player, who is very comfortable almost in anything, this Sabu, he's an all around person. And I just — sometimes I'm into a tune and the vocalist comes in, she knows when to come in, and the bass player doesn't even know what tune we're doing.

MR: I see.

AT: Like I look up and I say, "Ooh I'm sorry, man, we're in E flat." While she's singing I'll tell him this.

MR: Well that's a good way to lead I think. It keeps people on their toes.

AT: Yeah, what's that saying, I don't know whether it came from India or England, but he governs less — he that governs best that governs less. Something like that. So I have several of these things in my mind. Like don't answer the phone on the first ring. All these things.

MR: Well that's funny because you don't want people to think that you're just sitting by the phone waiting to grab it. Right?

AT: Yep. Okay so that's about where I am there.

MR: Well one thing that I'm really interested in is your childhood memories of New York and just growing up. You were born in 1921 is that right?

AT: Yes. A long time ago.

MR: Do you recall as a child anything special about the depression years?

AT: You know we never had the chance to actually think about it as young people. I mean that was the older people's — that was their thoughts on that. But as a young person I grew up and I had a pretty nice life. We had great Christmases, great Thanksgivings, man it couldn't have been any better really. We never thought we were poverty stricken or anything like that. We were normal, rich kids.

MR: You had a rich family life?

AT: Yes. A rich thinking family. Because my mother was very frugal. That's what made the difference. She knew how to spend or not spend a dollar. She was very — I don't know, I did not pick up on any of that. None of it wore off on me. My money goes before I get it.

MR: Really.

AT: So I can't say I'm good at that. I probably could be if I just could say no, if I could use the word no to people that come to me — I have certain people that come to me for money, a certain person rather, I could personalize. And I just can't say no to blood. Can't say no to the kids. So I don't know whether I'm being an enabler or what you may call it but I'm a parent first, an enabler second. But like going back to my younger days, we had like I said great Thanksgivings and great Christmases. You couldn't ask for anything better.

MR: Your mother sounded like she was pretty determined to have her kids in show business?

AT: Oh God, yeah. Ma saw all these Shirley Temple pictures and the Nicholas Brothers, and well anyhow, regardless of what she thought it was a contribution. We made a contribution. Because as kids we went out and worked these, you know like club affairs and things like that. And we were the entertainment. So it was money in our hands and in her hands, that she knew what to do with. So that's about the size of that.

MR: When you took dance lessons, what kind of dancing were you required to learn? Was it tap dancing?

AT: Yeah. Tap dancing and gymnastic type things, acrobats you know. I was pretty good at tumbling, blum-blum, flips and stuff.

MR: Yeah.

AT: Yeah. And we did little stage shows with this dance school, it was the Willis Lane Dance School — man, my mind is sharp.

MR: Whew — got the names, wow.

AT: They were a dance team that finally wound up married and had opened a dance school. And my mother saw this ad or they called or something, you know how they do. And we became all of a sudden a part of this thing. And there was a selection of about six or five kids that this school or this man of the school decided to give us — like say you had sixty kids going there, but you took five people out of this and made like a small show out of them. And my sister and I were one of them and there was another guy, the Padgetts, it was brother and sister, and there was this girl singer called Rae Harrison. I predicted great things for her but it never developed. She went sidewards I guess you might call it. She got into a club and stayed there and the longevity ruined her I think, you know a continuous thing. She became part of the furniture. So she didn't really want to go anywhere.

MR: Were you known, like in school, did you and your brother or your sister have this kind of like reputation as entertainers?

AT: No not really. Not in the school. Except like I had bit parts in school plays, like as a bird or something, sitting on a desk with bird crap on. But never any for what I wanted to be. And I think I was too early in the music scene. But they did select me for these plays, to do something. You know one play they had me doing — what is this guy called — Flip Phillips, when he did that woman thing, that girl thing?

MR: Oh Flip Wilson?

AT: Yeah. He's a comedian. Well anyhow he does this imitation of a woman.

MR: And you got to do that?

AT: I got to do one of those impressions, uncomfortably, because I think they put high heels on me and I'm wiggling. But that was the extent of my vaudevillian life.

MR: Well you went from being a woman impersonator and a bird to being in a Gershwin production, so that was quite a leap.

AT: Yeah. Ooh that was heavy.

MR: Yeah.

AT: The transition there was heavy. But like when I first realized what this thing was, this *Porgy & Bess* was, it was — they had rehearsals at a place called the Gill Theater. And it was just a little theater. And on the stage there was like long boards or something, and Coca Cola boxes and they went from one to the other, and entrances would be marked

where to come in for people. And I says damn, the school plays were better than this. You know I didn't realize that something different was coming up. Then I heard the music. I heard the chorus under Eva Jessye Choir and his Chorus, and they were singing these parts that sounded very different from the choral things I'd been hearing. And one day I got up there and in between the breaks and stuff I got up and I looked at this music and by the way I had been studying like from ten years old and I was going to this teacher four, five days a week, every day a different page. So I was reading like specks and stuff. What's that? Oh that's just the dot you know, so I'll read it anyhow. So anyhow I'm up there and I'm reading this score and I'm seeing how beautiful this music is and then one of the chorus or someone said would you play that? Can you play that for us for a minute while we—" and it became a news item. I was 14 at that time. It says young pianist or something, plays Gershwin's music. So that's how that developed.

MR: Right. And then people started wanting you to almost be like a rehearsal pianist or something so they could work on their parts?

AT: Well not exactly because there was strict union things. They had to adhere to their contracts. See my contract was as a juvenile kid in the village, which by the way, Gershwin would give me more things to do than I was getting paid to do, you know? I don't know how much he thought I was getting paid, but at first he had me take — I was the goat guy, I was the goat, and I had to make friends with this damn thing with the horns you know, and I would be the one to lead Porgy out on his initial entrance, lead him through the gate and up to the — sometimes this damn goat didn't look like it didn't want to stop and the pit orchestra was there and I'm putting on the brakes you know, I'm saying stop. So that happened a couple of times. But then there were different goats in different towns or sometimes different goats on different occasions. You know what I mean? But I had my time with those goats. That was not a happy situation.

MR: I see.

AT: Yes. But that was my thing there. And then he had me, there was a man doing the shoeshine bit in tempo with, the tune was "I Got Plenty of Nothing" which had a nice [scats] so there was a gentleman doing the shoeshine bit. So he says, "Let Al do that." You know? Man, what next? Here I go I'm doing the patted — you know with the patted beat? [scats] things like that. Then all of a sudden he comes up with there's no one up there in the hurricane scene for that, to rattle the shutters, you know, as the wind blows. He says, "Put little Al up there." I said damn.

MR: That's what you get for having rhythm. He knew that you could do it, right?

AT: Well you know the funny thing, this is where I learned how to conduct. Because I was on the right stage up on the second floor and the conductor was right down below me. Alexander — what was his name now — well anyhow—

MR: I had it written down. I can't remember either. So you had to watch him?

AT: No I didn't have to watch him. But sometimes they would look up and my shutters weren't rattling because I'm busy looking at the conductor.

MR: You were fascinated by what he was doing?

AT: Yes. I liked what he was doing and what the sound of the orchestra — when I heard that music I said this is no child's play here. You know? And when I saw the scenery, oof, God. Catfish Row. That's what I call my street now — now that you mentioned it, one day, about Monk and us, maybe I'd better call this little place where I live Catfish Row. Because of your last name. So I labeled it Catfish Row.

MR: Nice. Well how did the audiences respond to *Porgy & Bess* at the time?

AT: Oh controversial. I mean they didn't know whether it was an opera or whether it was a musical you know. And I'll tell you, it had more meat than it did potatoes. This thing went, I was only in the initial performances of it. But this thing went all over the world. I mean I'm in school while this thing is still going on, and people were saying we wish we had a *Porgy & Bess* in this town, you know and that town. And I just had a book lately that expressed all these things, that *Porgy & Bess* was doing diplomatically world wide you know. And I said gee, I missed all of that.

MR: Did you get, in the theater when you were working, did they have an integrated audiences?

AT: Yes, yes in the theater. But I went on a — what would you call these things now that people go on — almost like a circus. And I went on this one, this circus bit like. And I was the band director for it. And they were separated audiences because we went to the seaboard, all the way down south. And there was audiences, half this side, there was a rope down the middle.

MR: Oh the old, the rope thing.

AT: Yeah. And what the hell, it wasn't bad, I mean everybody knew what was happening.

MR: What they were supposed to do. What year would that have been? Or around what time?

AT: '39 I think it was. "38, '39. Something around there.

MR: And did you have an integrated band?

AT: No, no I didn't have an integrated band. I had comedians and whatnot. And one comedian, he used to knock me out, he would have this black face stuff on you know, and he would get in front of the audience and says, "Yep it was me and these six other white boys standing on the corner." And I used to crack up every time he said that. I don't know why. But it was funny to me you know. It was funny to me.

MR: Well it must have been a little hard for you to function well in school, wasn't it? When you were doing these shows and things?

AT: No because they made special privileges. They took me out of one school and put me in another school that was mainly for kids who were working — something — I don't know how it was turned around, but anyhow I know I had certain days out of school. I think I went maybe to school one day a week or so, something like that. Well because there was a performance every day.

MR: Do you recall what you got paid?

AT: What, in *Porgy & Bess*?

MR: Yeah.

AT: Ten dollars I think it was.

MR: Ten dollars per?

AT: This is what this manager, who had all of us kids under contract, this is all the kids got. That's all.

MR: Was it ten dollars per show or ten dollars per week?

AT: No ten dollars per week. This guy was — he was reaping up the money man. But he had a separate contract with the management of the theater and a separate one with us, showing the mothers and things how much — see I mean in those days that was a bit of money, in those days. You could do something. And my brother and I were in it so it was double.

MR: Right. Twenty dollars a week.

AT: Yeah man.

MR: And the way your mother was, she could really stretch that.

AT: Yeah man, she was great with it. She was great with it. Yeah. So it wasn't hard. We were doing what she wanted us to do. She wanted us to be in show business and we just went ahead and did it.

MR: She must have been happy, at least at that point.

AT: Yeah, oh man she was happy. She was happy up until the day I decided I didn't want to do that, I wanted to be a musician. And then she gave me an option or an alternative to either live with her or go live with my father, who was a musician also. And they had separated so I had my choice. I went with my father for a while because of the liberal attitude he had.

MR: I see. What was it about being a musician that upset her?

AT: Because I was like my father. My father was a musician and her and him couldn't get along and there was this controversial thing.

MR: So she said well you want to be like your father then go live with him?

AT: Yeah. Not in those words but anyhow that's how I wound up. And her — they couldn't get along, it was terrible. There was fights and whatnot. But other than those little fights

we had a great life, we had a great family life, until the day of separation. Other than that it was—

MR: And you were what, 17 or 18 at that time?

AT: No I was younger than that.

MR: Younger.

AT: Yeah they had been separated a long time before that. I was maybe 15, somewhere around there. I can't orchestrate the exact date.

MR: Right. And you got around the city by yourself in those times? Did you take the subway and all those kinds of things?

AT: Oh yeah, yeah. I was city slick.

MR: City slick. Nice term.

AT: Yeah I knew how to get around and had my little ways. One day I decided to play hooky from school and found it to be the most boring thing I'd ever witnessed in my life. You know? I'd hear all these kids, "Hey I'm playing hooky tomorrow." Man this must be great. Guess I'll play hooky. And I played hooky and I couldn't find anything to do because all the kids was at school, so there was nobody — oh man it was terrible, terrible. So as a result I stopped playing hooky, because I had no explanation as to where I was or what I did. And the report came back to my mother. "Where were you, what did you do?" And I..

MR: It wasn't worth it, right?

AT: It really wasn't worth it. It really wasn't.

MR: I'm curious what kind of music would have been played in your house when you were growing up? Did you have a record player?

AT: Yeah. You know my father had a band, he had about an eight or ten piece band. And the trombone player was a piano teacher and that's how I got into being taught how to play. But the music was — you know I really don't know because we weren't home that much. Actually as kids we were out in the street all the time and the only time we would actually have time to listen to music was at dinner time. We ate at six o'clock every night. Six o'clock you'd better be home.

MR: I see.

AT: And that's probably about the time, and then we shut it off to eat I guess.

MR: Would it have been radio?

AT: Yes radio. Yeah, the first time I saw the radio come in the house I'm looking behind it to see the people. Where is he talking from? I was very curious. I'm looking behind the thing, the tubes and stuff. That was a really exciting thing for me to hear this radio and these people talking. And my father was sort of a ham too, a ham radio operator. He liked

to build sets you know. And he built his little keyboard and he used to get other voices on it, you know, and it was interesting. Like the truck drivers use today.

MR: Right. The CBs.

AT: Yeah. So that's what it was — let me check/see something here. Okay. It's not bad.

MR: Do you recall when the term "jazz" became known to you?

AT: When I first started that's what it was called.

MR: And that was the kind of popular music of the time?

AT: Yeah. And then it developed into swing with the big bands. But jazz was the first word being used, and I think it was a terminology of the brothels. It came from the brothels. Tunes like, "Jazz Me Baby" and all that. And then it developed with the big bands into swing, swing time, and from there it just went helter skelter.

MR: It sure did.

AT: Every man for himself. And that's what happened. And out of that division of bands and musicians came everything: came bop, and bop I think was the first offspring of it. And then came the — what do you call this abstract jazz? This stuff that played out of tempo and all that?

MR: Yeah, free jazz.

AT: So you're still getting some more influence in the music that wasn't there, but what happened I guess, if it wasn't for that we would still be listening to the same music over and over. So what these people are putting into the music today is really good for the music, it's good for the feel.

MR: Were you able to dance at — did you go to see swing bands and dance for those things?

AT: Yeah I used to go to the Savoy. But it wasn't to dance, I was there to listen to the band. Sometimes I'd get kicked on the ankle, you know, while I was listening. I used to love the Coleman Hawkins Band. He had a concept which I liked. It was the bass player and the drummer soloing at the same time.

MR: Really?

AT: But that was great because I think the bass was just playing straight fours or something, but in his own way, and the drummer was playing different beats alternately, sort of contrapuntal sort of playing. That's why I liked that band. Most of the other — and Ellington. I don't care what I was doing it stopped if the Ellington sound came on. I loved the Ellington band. Some of the things I didn't understand but I knew they were great because of the sound. They had that sound with the baritone leading.

MR: Yeah. What a master orchestrator.

AT: Yes he was. And I learned how to do that when a friend of mine, Bilal Abdullah I think, yes, he had a workshop. And it was formed of like guys who just wanted to come down Saturday early and work out — you know how people workout? Well this was a workout

for musicians. So they came together and then guys would bring other fellas and he asked me to take over this thing because — to take over this workshop because he had to go on an assignment to like Gowanda or somewhere. He was into this rehab thing.

MR: Gowanda, right.

AT: Yeah Gowanda. So I took it over. But when he got back I had a band. I actually had a band and they were playing stocks, but they weren't playing them sharp enough for me. So I heard this Duke Ellington thing called "Normins" — "Snibor" is a tune. It's Robins backwards. And anyhow it seemed simple enough to get, and I was able to steal the right notes and orchestrate it, he had the right notes. And I wrote this orchestration out, I think it took me about 15 minutes. Because if it takes me any longer I'm through with it. I've got to do things just like that. So anyhow I wrote down the score, a four line score that's all I had. And I would choose the voices out of these four lines. And solos, and the backgrounds. Everything was done out of these four lines. And so I took it to this rehearsal. Now these guys were having difficulty with the other music. I took this thing down one Saturday morning and I said, "Fellas, you want to try this?" And you know what? They played it like they had been playing it all the time. And the sound was there. The Ellington sound was there. And so we decided we were going to make this workshop the Ellington workshop like. Then I wrote other things, I wrote a thing called — copied from him of course — called "Jam with Sam," and it featured a trombone player. And I wrote the solo out and everything. And this was the best solo this guy ever did, but he loved it and we played this at the auditorium in Buffalo downtown, and it got a standing ovation. And I says hell, what'll I do now? I don't want to go back to the top, so I'm going around to each section, Section E, Section E, Section E, okay here we go. Don't start at the top, start at the middle somewhere. But this went over great man. And I never saw that in Buffalo, like at the auditorium. I mean yeah, nice, but a standing ovation, that was something, wow, man. That was really great. So I chalked that off as an achievement. Okay I'd orchestrated, I'd done that, and I'm through with that part because who's there to orchestrate for? You know there are no large bands, all the bands are small groups. And so I just said okay, check it off, on that, I've played piano for eighty — not eighty, seventy years almost, and I've done this and I did that and I just check them off now. So now I lay in the bed and I watch T.V. and people say, "You should be up doing something." I say, "Look, I waited eighty years to do this, what I'm doing. And everybody's telling me to get up and do something.

MR: You deserve the time to sit here and watch television, right?

AT: So what is this? They're kicking me out of the bed.

MR: Yeah they want to impose their own thoughts on what you should be doing, right?

AT: Yeah. And I don't want to do that. I waited to do this. I couldn't wait long enough. I didn't stop until I was 70 you know, and I was working at a behavioral center for young men and I found myself on the floor a few times, trying to break up fights and whatnot, and it was something for me to really get out of. I shouldn't have been in it that long, not at 70 years old. But it was an enjoyable feat I'll say, because I was supposed to be a music instructor, but different things would — you know how—

MR: Sure, discipline problems.

AT: Yes. They used to have a saying, if it isn't sex it's violence. One comes out of the other. And you had some of that going on there — fights about whose mate is whose. So there wasn't anything to be done about that. Go ahead.

MR: When — it's hard I think for people who talk to you about the days, the bop days, to remember that a lot of the fellas you played with and that played with you were not big names like we think of them.

AT: That's right.

MR: And we always think of those days and wow, Charlie Parker and Benny Harris, and what a thing, it must have been an amazing thing for all those people. But at the time everybody was just learning, is that right?

AT: That's right, that's right. It was like the school. You know I had the band. The Boston Club made me the musical director for the band. And he let me hire who I wanted, and that was another workshop scene. I was doing the writing there for a small combo and I didn't quite accomplish what I wanted to writing there. Because there was another guy that was writing and his writing sounded so good, you know I couldn't match that so I just gave up writing, until, and that was in the forties or something. And I just gave it up until I wrote for the big band. And I said oh I can do it. But anyhow, like you say, bebop, I'd never heard of that name until I went overseas. And a young man came overseas and I had this band, the 201st Army Ground Forces Band that they made me director of that out of — not out of desperation choice or whatever, but anyhow a sergeant left a note that when he left for them to find me. And I wasn't — I was in the hospital. I had a, what do you call it, something wrong with my lower extremities. I was — one night I went out to take a pee and I did it in a can and the can was like rusty and stuff and I got caught on this can.

MR: Ouch.

AT: Ouch is right. But that caused me to have damaging results down there. And these guys found me in this hospital and they transported me to the band that was supposed to get me, but that band was leaving to go to the United States. This was in Germany. And this band was going home. But I didn't want to come back to the US. I wanted to stay over in Germany longer. I don't know why. But anyhow there was another band, that 161 or

something, and I said I'll stay here, because this was the only chance I had to work as a conductor. So I stayed as the conductor for that band. And plus I signed up for six months longer. I said I must be crazy. But I had everything there that I wanted to work with. I had musicians and bands and stuff.

MR: Was it playing military music or was it playing swing music or all of that?

AT: It was both. I made a swing unit out of the military unit. We used to do parades and things like that, and I would select a guy to be the guy that looked good, you know a nice tall guy to be the band director, and I would just stand on the side as the musical director. But anyhow out of this big band I made a show like. I had a small band, like a six piece or seven piece group out of all the stars, and then I had the sixteen piece band and I had a guy who liked to sing, and I had a guy who liked to tap dance and tell jokes and stuff, so I made a show out of it. I said hey, we're in show business.

MR: All right. Play for the officers' club and things like that?

AT: Yeah, yeah. Well not really officers, other companies, other Army companies that didn't have any that wanted entertainment, we'd go over and play for them. Yeah it was nice.

MR: Was the service pretty much segregated at that time?

AT: Definitely at the time I was in it was segregated. But I didn't know it. I mean to me I had always lived like this. But I lived in the ghetto neighborhood, I didn't realize anything then. I don't know where my mind was. None of this bothered me.

MR: Well when you're in it, and not observing it, I think it's different. When people write about it later and make — maybe at the time it wasn't a big deal it was just the way things were.

AT: You had a few spokesmen in the race that knew what was going on or wasn't happy with what was going on, and wanted to change it, you now, not realizing that in some instances they were putting people in jeopardy you see. Like they were taking — actually when they did that they — what do you call it — saturated the black teachers and stuff out of jobs because now anybody could come in and get those jobs you see. Before when you had — you understand where I'm coming from?

MR: Yeah I think I do.

AT: Yeah. They were actually black positions you might say. And these were gone. Anybody could take — like even just a janitor, now it was open to anyone.

MR: I see what you mean. So by opening things up it was almost detrimental to some people.

AT: That's right in some cases. Although — and it's funny that time, time is the essence of anything that happens. Like the phone calls. If you wait the time will develop its own self and that's what should have happened but didn't happen. See the pressure was being put on and these marches in Selma where the kids were trampled on and the water thing, and you know when all of this would have developed in a sense of time. I would say that

wouldn't have been necessary. A great leader, a man who led them was killed by it, and so I really don't understand why we won't wait for that phone call.

MR: That's a good way to put it. You said something else that I had read kind of in that regard and it was about people calling certain entertainers Uncle Toms?

AT: Uncle Toms?

MR: Uncle Toms, like that they were — and you had said that these were the people who paved the way for the important people to follow them.

AT: That's right. They were the backs of what we stepped on to get where things are today. Like Steppin Fetchit. He was one of the great ones. And most of the black comedians were really — they had foresight. They would make fun of situations that soon developed into a situation of reality. So we have them to thank a lot for whatever happened. But things you see, and why I say that is because things have not really changed. Things have not really changed. In fact there is development on this supremacy thing right now. The Ku Klux Klan or something, you still have things like that that have not obliterated any of the feelings, and they're out campaigning against the black thing, and the blacks are trying to overcome, still trying to overcome. So it really hasn't changed anything. And then now you have the influx of foreign, oh well we're all foreigners to put it, you know, but now you have the Asian thing that you didn't have before, as much as you have now, and now you've got what to me seems — I don't understand how it happened — but when the Polish people were in dominance in this part — in Buffalo you know — there weren't signs and things up in Polish. But now that the Latin people have come here, now you have signs and things in Latin. And I'm saying why? What happened? What transition is this? Now we have to learn two languages. Now that's another case that I see where the Latin people who come here that know how to speak English and know how to speak Latin can mop up the jobs that require bilingual techniques, see? Now it's difficult for say a person to go in that speaks Latin or Spanish or whatever and there's a black person there that's a receptionist or something and she don't know how to deal with this. "Lucy, will you come here? I can't understand what this gentleman is saying." She's not going to have that job long. See? You have to have a bilingual quality in order to — that's one thing about it. So I stepped out of line one night. I was at a little table in Fanny's and there's another Tinney in Buffalo called Herb Tinney. And his daughter married a Latin person. And I'm just rolling off at the mouth about the job saturation you know. Not realizing I'm saying some of these insulting things. I mean they weren't really insulting, they were factual. But facts sometimes are sort of, and I didn't realize it. So I had to apologize. But when I went — this Tinney that I'm talking about, works at the library downtown. And when I went downtown one day to the library where he works I said, "I'm sorry," but he says uh huh, you were right. He said because a friend of mine

says you're going to insult him that he was going to have to learn Latin in order to speak to his grandchildren. You see? So I wasn't wrong but I was wrong in the time and place.

MR: Right. You were a little too honest for the time and place.

AT: Yeah, yeah, yeah. But as they left we were all shaking hands, you know.

MR: Yeah. Well that's a very interesting point you make about people creating separateness with the language and not seeming to want to assimilate into what is here.

AT: Yes. When I went overseas anybody could speak English as a second language. You could speak to anybody over there in Germany — I was in Germany, France, and everybody "oh hello, you speak American?" He's watching his I'm going to watch mine. I'm doing okay.

MR: Doing okay? Well good, you keep an eye on that. You had some other really interesting things I think you've said, that you were never awe-struck by anyone.

AT: That's right. Only by the clouds and the heavens. That's the only thing. Like some people will say Art Tatum, you know. Art Tatum, he was a good piano player, he was about the best piano player around. But you know the funny thing is he knew every damn piano player in the neighborhood except me. You know what I mean? This kind of — not bothered me much — but it made me wonder. And every time somebody would say, "Hey Al did you ever meet Tatum?" And I says here we go again. He lived up — oh hey man and I'd shake his hand and he never recognized me as a piano player. I guess because I never sat down behind him. I sat down before him once and played and he sat down behind me and I don't know whether that was something funny there or—

MR: Maybe he felt a little threatened by you?

AT: You know I'm telling you man, this was funny because there was a movie starlet called Isabel Jewel — I don't know whether you heard of her or not but she was way back in like the Hopkins people and all that, but her name was Isabel Jewel. And she came down to this Monroe's Uptown House with one of the stars from Billy Rose's Aquacade. And I'm coming off the stand, now this is going to hit you in the head man. I'm coming off the stand and she jumps up out of her seat and hugs me and says, "You're better than Art Tatum." I just thought this lady does not know piano players. But it made me feel good but then I don't know, but it didn't strike me as being a big compliment because of her competence as a person to acknowledge who is who you know what I mean.

MR: Yeah. I would take the compliment though.

AT: Yeah well I kind of take it like that. Especially with the big hug and stuff. She was a wonderful woman. But anyhow that's another thing that kind of bothered me or that stuck with me through the years I'd say. And I came all this way, 81 years, to find you, Monk Rowe, to tell this story to.

MR: And I appreciate hearing it. You know we like to think, those of us who weren't there again, we think that everybody got along all the time, that musicians liked each other and all those things, and musicians are just human beings too, right?

AT: I would hope so. Yeah. There's only one thing, there is a difference. We're more a diplomatic sect. And most people are. Like a plumber or something like that would not rub elbows with the kind of people musicians rub elbows with. And we have to like be on our toes as to what we say. Like I say I made that mistake, that social mistake, and other people wouldn't even regard that as — they'd say ah what the hell. But with us we have to, this can be — that could have been told to my boss, and like hey your piano player doesn't like Latin people. But in another situation, a situation would be ah the hell with him.

MR: Do you think that's partly because on the bandstand you're musically always negotiating with each other?

AT: Yeah. I think so. We have a connection — I think I told my bass player one time, we were talking and I don't know whether it was about money or not, I doubt if it was money because these guys never complained about the money — but I says, "You know man," I said, "it isn't all about the music." And why I said that I don't know. I said, "It isn't all about the music it's more or less about the camaraderie of the musicians. Some musicians you work with you don't really like to play with them because they may get on your nerves or may not play up to par, you understand what I mean? And they're actually at your coattails to help them. But there is a level, several levels of playing. And if one doesn't reach your level or something then you're uncomfortable with that. And you hope that the night goes faster than it did.

MR: I love the comment you made about at jam sessions and so forth that the people that don't play very well usually play the longest.

AT: Right.

MR: That's a great comment.

AT: Yeah they have the longest throats. Oh man that's terrible. Because the guys that know how to play, they make a statement and that's it. But the guys that don't, they just play on and on until you tell them to stop and let somebody else do it.

MR: Right. Maybe they don't know where they are and can't get out of it.

AT: That's a point. They don't know where the codas are. Yes. So that could happen.

MR: You know you I'm sure have some strong opinions about the drug scene at the time. And you stated that it was malnutrition that brought down a lot of those players.

AT: Hell yeah. Because they weren't eating. All their money was going into the drug situation. They were feeding the drug dealer. And actually they were living reclusively you know, by themselves, and just banging up all day or doing something, and nothing

else interested them except maybe their music, which they would maybe practice for four or five hours at a time. They were great practicers in my day. That's why they were all so good. Like Bird and Diz and the rest of them, Charlie — what's his name now — he was a trumpet player — Charlie Shavers, that's his name. And they were all terrific and because of their practice. They practiced, like they say you want to get to Carnegie Hall? Practice. And they finally made it to Carnegie Hall, believe it or not — not in the Carnegie Hall tradition but jazz in the Paul Whiteman tradition, taking jazz to Carnegie Hall.

MR: Well it must have been quite a challenge working with guys like Don Byas and so forth?

AT: Oh man. Don Byas. One night he took a tune, and I'm glad I knew the tune, and he said, "Let's go through the keys, Al." I said, "Oh no." He said, "Come on, man, you can—" I said, "I don't even know it in this key." But we went through all of the keys. And this is where I got all my schooling, from these guys. Him and another trumpet player, I forget his name now, but these guys were all my teachers. Not just one person, I had several teachers you know. I learned from several people.

MR: And it wasn't even like official lessons, it was just like on the job, right?

AT: Oh no, it was just — here's how you do this Al. And I would do it like that. Because like I used to love Teddy Wilson and I used to actually start playing similar to him. And then him and I became very good friends and I would go up to his house to get the data for an orchestration that I was going to do for him and his small group down at — what is it called, it was — well anyhow, he was in the bathroom shaving or something and I was playing the piano and he sticks his head out and he says, "You've been listening to Tatum, ey?" I said, "Oh no, no, no, I'm still a Wilson —" because I had been listening to Tatum.

MR: That's very interesting.

AT: And there was a lot of scale work and stuff and transpositions and transitions and stuff. But after a while I found him not so interesting as I thought he was.

MR: Teddy Wilson?

AT: No.

MR: Or Tatum?

AT: Tatum. Because of the similarities and how much further can you get out? How much can you get out of that?

MR: Do you think some of it was for show? I mean he had amazing—

AT: Actually, all of it was for show. I mean who would learn how to play like that just for their own self?

MR: Good point.

AT: In fact everybody out here that's doing something in the public is doing it for the public not for themselves.

MR: Right. That's true.

AT: I didn't study all what I learned — I didn't study that just to say hey I can do this stuff. Show me. That's what they want, show me.

MR: Well said.

AT: Yes.

MR: We haven't talked much about what society music was at the time. Now you got kind of disillusioned with the narcotic scene and so forth. And did you consciously say I'm going to get out of this?

AT: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

AT: I did.

MR: You had enough self preservation kind of?

AT: Yeah. Well actually I had had enough jazz. I would more or less say that this influx of drugs and stuff was an excuse for me to get out, you know, to go commercial. I went commercial and played show tunes and things. And I played for shows in Greenwich Village. And I enjoyed that more than I enjoyed the jazz scene. Because there was none of this competitive thing going on. When I was at Monroe's there was trumpet players trying to play higher than the other trumpets, or the saxophone player trying to play more notes. And you know it was like the axe cutting scene. And here we are at the piano playing behind these guys for like hours accompanying them for what they're doing. So I got tired of it.

MR: Yeah. You got a whole line of saxophone players waiting to sit in and you're back there.

AT: Oh man, some of them with the long throats that don't know when to stop, you know? So that was it. That was a good excuse for me to get out of it.

MR: Was — some of the names like Lester Lanin, was that the type of society bands you would play in or was it smaller groups?

AT: No. Now let me see now. Teddy Wilson had a band at Café Society that I did some arrangements for and it was not a Lombardo type thing, you know. It was just cool, you know, and it wasn't exhibition or anything like that. It was just playing nice music. I liked the society music. Especially Lester Lanin, he had a band who never had any arrangements of anything in front of him, they all played from their heads.

MR: They all played from—

AT: That's right. No music. They had their own heads and things they would play with.

MR: I see. Each like horn man would have a role to play?

AT: Yeah. He'd take his own part, his own, similar to the Ellington situation. They did that but then he got better and better readers and all them, they were able to exhibit what he wanted which was that tough playing like. But you take things like the "Crescendo and Diminuendo in Blue," now that, the best part of that — and that's a complicated arrangement actually, the arrangement is. But the solo, the 27 choruses, was the most interesting part about it. And this was all ad lib. But what followed that, like [scats] with the trumpets that followed was a tremendous arrangement. I remember one time I was at the library. And I asked to hear, to see if they had a track on "Main Stem," the Ellington tune. Because I don't know why, I fell in love with that tune. And they did have a track on it so they gave me the thing and I took it to the desk and I put my earphones on and I played this, and evidently, unconsciously, I was singing along with it. And the lady came over and said, "Mr. Tinney, you have to quiet down." I said, "Oh I'm sorry."

MR: You had no idea you were doing that.

AT: I had no idea, I was completely lost in it. And I haven't heard anybody play it yet.

MR: Really.

AT: I could have made my own arrangement of it. I'm better at transcribing Ellington than other transcribers do. Because they try to be too technical. I just try to — just give me the right notes. If it's a — what do you call it — a off-sounding tone, that's the one I'll hear. And that's the one I'm going to write.

MR: The dissonant one?

AT: Yeah. The dissonant one. That's the one I'm going to write down. Because the thirds and the sixths and the sevenths and all, they'll be heard within the chord. But this one note here will make the difference. So that's what I learned how to transcribe from him. And like I say with that band that I was in or with, that 16 or 17 piece band, when I was writing I was writing purely Ellington. And it was amazing because there was a saxophone player by the name of Jeff Hackworth I think his name was. And we did a little concert, it was a competition you might say, between bands. And when we came off I went over, with this guy. He came up to me and said, "Man, that band sounds like the Ellington band." And I wanted to hug him man, because this is what I was—

MR: That's what you wanted to hear.

AT: That's what I wanted. But when he said it, and this was another person's opinion besides mine you know. But I loved it man.

MR: What is your view on the teaching of jazz? How much can you teach?

AT: I don't think you can teach. The reason why I say that is because I wasn't taught. That's the only reason I can make that statement. I did a lot of listening. I got some books and stuff that had little riffs and things in it, you know, but mostly listening. It was the science of sound actually. And some people can get — you know you have to be endowed I

believe, a bit. Because there are some people who've got it and some people who don't have it. Some people who have been playing for years and they still sound like crap you know. And there are some people who play today and tomorrow they sound much better. So I think it's more or less what you're endowed with.

MR: Yeah. I think you're right. And there's lots of methods out now that they are entitled "Anyone Can Improvise."

AT: Yeah, that's right.

MR: I'm not sure it's true.

AT: But improvising is an old thing though. Like that's what they were doing — I believe that there was similarities between the saloons and the salons.

MR: Good statement.

AT: You know? Because I can imagine Beethoven and those guys getting together in a saloon or a salon or whatever you want to call it and saying, "Man listen to this: I found out this diminished chord fits with this seventh chord." And this is what I can imagine, the life they lived. They can't have been isolated.

MR: Yeah. And those guys liked — those classical composers liked to break rules too, didn't they?

AT: Oh definitely, definitely. I found a few and I corrected them.

MR: Is that right?

AT: I did. I corrected a Beethoven thing, the Sonata, the "Moonlight Sonata," I said why did he do that? He could have did this. He didn't work within the rules. And Gershwin I did the same thing with. I said he's doing contrary motion because of a rule when he doesn't have to, he can do similar motion. [scats]

MR: So why did he do that?

AT: Rules. He went by the rules. Contrary motion. One angling this way and one angling the other way, which is one thing that he really wrote by — strictly by the rules. And he came out beautiful. I don't see how — it was his mind.

MR: Yeah you credit him with a lot of harmonic stuff too that people picked up later.

AT: Oh man, he was the first one I heard, well in my kind of music, playing in chordal harmony, fourths, harmony in fourths, and the clusters that he used to — he had an introduction, the introduction to the overture you might say, to *Porgy & Bess* was like strictly pentatonic. [scats] And then he went into sevenths in a cluster with the strings [scats]. I mean this was all by the rules.

MR: He sure knew how to use the rules, didn't he?

AT: Yes. That's the whole thing. Knowing how to use them. It's like we have laws, civil rights laws and whatnot. And they're making all these changes in the laws when the law by itself would have stood up. You know. If we say well we can't have candy today and

somebody wants to have candy today, well they're trying to be outside the law, and well why can't you make it different between today and tomorrow? Can you say well okay in your case we'll make it — in your case — that's where the changes of the law comes. And well in your case we'll change the rule, see? And they'll put an item in or something like that which will not change the rule but changes the way the rule is used. So that's what I say about that.

MR: You've had quite an amazing life. If you think about your life, what's the most important thing for you? That's a heck of a question isn't it? But I'm wondering if you have a —

AT: Yeah that is quite a question. What's important to me?

MR: Yeah.

AT: That's funny you said that. A good woman. A good woman to most men. A good woman. I just heard something recently, a guy said if you have a good woman you have a good life. If you have a bad woman, or a woman that ain't up to par, you'll become a great philosopher. Because you start making things out of situations. So I believe that's all I'm looking for. When I find that I'll be all right.

MR: All right.

AT: Yeah. But so far it hasn't happened, in 81 years. I keep getting duds.

MR: Is that right?

AT: Duds. One dud after the other.

MR: Well it gives you something to look forward to I guess.

AT: Yes. Maybe that's why I'm still alive.

MR: Yes. You can't rush things I guess.

AT: Yes indeed. I just say Al, you really don't need it, I don't know why you're looking for it. Looking for something you don't need. But I think I need it. I can stand on the corner and talk about it.

MR: Yeah. You have grandchildren now?

AT: Yes. Yes. I had two daughters and one of my daughters had two daughters. Just like I did you know. And my other daughter had a son. She spoiled the transition. She went from girls to boys. No, my first wife, well my only wife, and I said, "If you bring a boy in here you and the boy goes out." Now I wasn't thinking, this wasn't forethought or anything but I'm realizing what those poor boys have to go through. You know? They don't only have to think of themselves as providers, but now it comes to war and comes other things that they're involved in. You know the war scene wasn't heavy, to me, but to some other people it was heavy, it was costly. It cost them something they brought up from a child and all of a sudden the man puts a uniform on him and throws him a gun and says you go out there and kill or be killed. What kind of — you know — you wouldn't do that to a dog.

MR: Well it's really been fascinating talking with you today.

AT: Thank you.

MR: You know we might have to do another part here sometime because you've got so much to say.

AT: Okay. Well this is the end of it like?

MR: Well we're running out of tape.

AT: Okay. I'm running out too, so everything turned out all right. It turned out beautiful. I enjoyed this.

MR: Well thank you for your time I really appreciate it.

AT: I don't know if you were looking for something educational, which I'm not really a clinical person. So I'm glad you asked me about my life and you did ask me about children and grandchildren. No one else does this.

MR: Well those are important things.

AT: They are.

MR: It's not just the music as you said.

AT: Right. It's not only the music.